DMC notes on The Perfect Match

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Notes in Preface

Lenses: False Needs (Marcuse), Surveillance Capitalism (Zuboff)

In the short story "The Perfect Match," the protagonist, Sai, confronts the fact that his desires and preferences are not his own, but being fed to him through chatbots. This presents a modern look at the disappearing line between free will and the "suggestions" of corporate-controlled AI.

One issue this story raises is that of "false needs"[1], that is desires created by capitalist consumer society – such as the urge to buy certain products or have certain relationships – that seem personal but actually keep people dependent, distracted, and less free.

Also relevant is "surveillance capitalism"[2], which is the idea that companies profit by collecting, analyzing, predicting, and influencing people's behavior, turning personal data into a tool for influence and commercial gain.

- *Can you relate to how the protagonist is controlled through false needs?*
- *Can you relate to how our independence is limited because corporations are always observing us and trying to influence us?*
- *How important is privacy to the main character, and to you?*

[1] On false needs, see:

- *One-Dimensional Man: Studies in the Ideology of Advanced Industrial Society*, Herbert Marcuse, Beacon Press, 1964.
- Herbert Marcuse's False Needs Theory – YouTube.
- From 1984 to One-Dimensional Man: Critical Reflections on Orwell and Marcuse, Douglas Kellner.

[2] On surveillance capitalism, see:

- *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism: The Fight for a Human Future at the New Frontier of Power*, Shoshana Zuboff, Profile Books, 2019.

  > "The titanic power struggles of the twentieth century were between industrial capital and labor, but the twenty-first century finds surveillance capital pitted against the entirety of our societies in a bloodless battle for power and profit as violent as any the world has seen."

- The Age of Surveillance Capitalism – Wikipedia.
- Shoshana Zuboff's The Age of Surveillance Capitalism: A Guide to Fighting Back – YouTube.